

MERCURY



Mercury's year
is **shorter**
than its day.

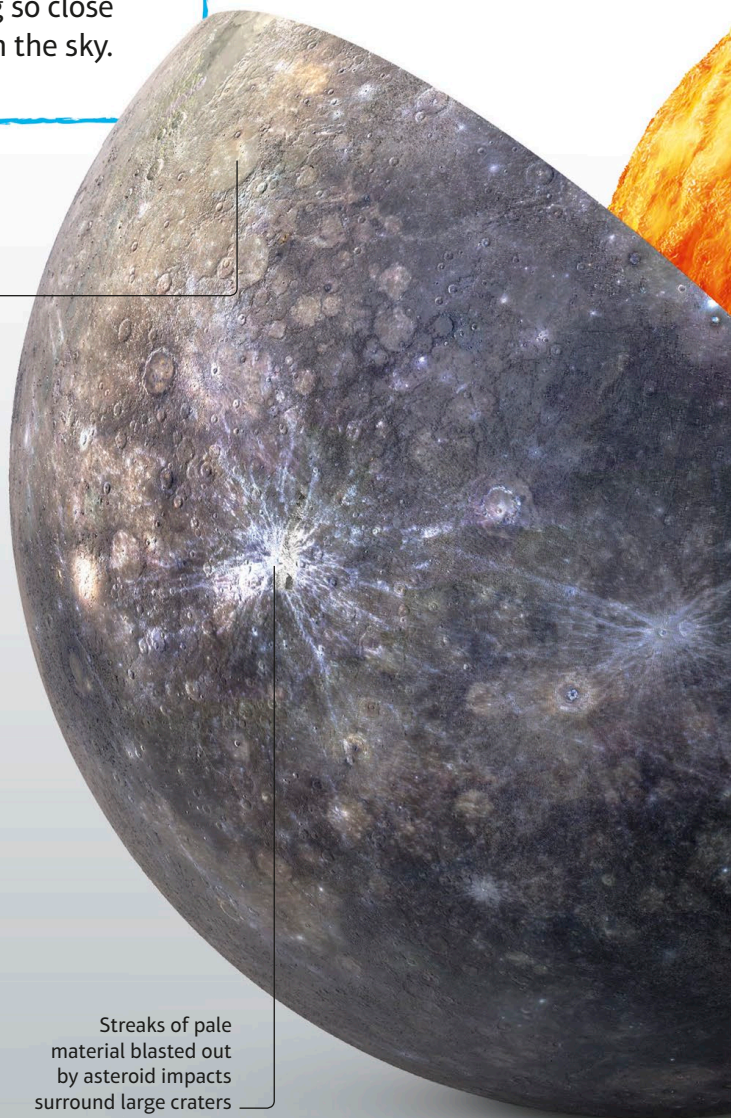
The smallest planet in the Solar System, Mercury is the closest world to the Sun. Like our Moon, it is heavily cratered, a result of impacts by asteroids in the past. This mini-world also seems to have shrunk, like a dried-up apple. As a result, the planet is crisscrossed with "wrinkle ridges". Being so close to the Sun, Mercury is difficult to spot in the sky.

Craters on Mercury, such as the Mendelssohn Crater, are often named after composers and artists

IMPACT BASIN



At 1,300 km (800 miles) across, the Caloris Basin is the biggest of Mercury's scars. It was gouged out by a collision with a giant asteroid 3.8 billion years ago. This coloured image shows the lava floods that filled the basin in orange, and later craters in blue.



Streaks of pale material blasted out by asteroid impacts surround large craters